

The Abraham Accords

UAE, Bahrain, Sudan, Morocco, and the Saudi Normalization That October 7 Paused

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Executive Summary

The Abraham Accords, signed in a series of ceremonies at the White House in September–December 2020, constituted the most significant structural realignment of Arab-Israeli relations since the Egypt-Israel peace treaty of 1979 and the Jordan-Israel peace treaty of 1994. The agreements — brokered primarily by Senior Advisor Jared Kushner and Special Envoy Avi Berkowitz under the Trump administration — normalised diplomatic, commercial, and security relations between Israel and four Arab states: the United Arab Emirates (signed September 15, 2020), Bahrain (September 15, 2020), Sudan (October 23, 2020), and Morocco (December 10, 2020). Each agreement involved a distinct US political concession to the Arab signatory: the UAE received a commitment to the sale of F-35 fighter jets and other advanced weapons systems; Sudan received removal from the US State Sponsors of Terrorism list; Morocco received formal US recognition of its sovereignty over Western Sahara. The agreements were structurally novel in bypassing the traditional Palestinian Authority condition that normalisation must await a Palestinian state — a departure from the Arab Peace Initiative framework of 2002 that Arab governments had maintained as official doctrine for 18 years. The ultimate prize of the normalization architecture was and remains Saudi Arabia — the largest Arab state, the custodian of Islam's holiest sites, and the state whose alignment with Israel would carry psychological and political weight across the Muslim world that no previous normalisation had approached. Saudi-Israeli normalization negotiations reached an advanced stage by mid-2023 before the October 7 Hamas attack paused all formal discussions.

Part I — The UAE-Israel Normalization

The formal announcement of UAE-Israel normalization came on August 13, 2020 — a date whose acceleration beyond the agreed timeline for West Bank annexation reflected the careful choreography of the Kushner-led negotiation. The Netanyahu government's coalition agreement with Benny Gantz's Blue and White party had included a commitment to apply Israeli sovereignty to portions of the West Bank from July 1, 2020 — a process that international observers widely described as annexation and that would have foreclosed Palestinian statehood by permanently incorporating West Bank territory into Israel proper. The UAE and the Trump administration reached an understanding under which Israel would suspend — not abandon — the annexation plans, allowing MBZ to present the normalization to Arab audiences as having extracted a meaningful concession for Palestinian interests.

The commercial dimensions of normalization were substantial and rapid. UAE-Israel bilateral trade reached approximately \$2.7 billion in 2022, the first full year of normal trade relations. By 2023, trade volumes exceeded \$3 billion, driven by technology, cybersecurity, agricultural technology, healthcare,

and tourism . The UAE received 228,000 Israeli tourists in 2022, a remarkable figure given that no commercial air connections had existed before September 2020 . The business relationship extended into multiple sectors: Shaare Zedek Medical Center in Jerusalem established a partnership with UAE healthcare institutions; Israeli fintech companies established UAE licensing and operational bases; and agricultural technology — in which Israel possesses globally recognised expertise — found ready application in the UAE's food security diversification programme .

The security and intelligence dimension of the relationship, less visible but arguably more strategically significant, centred on the shared Iranian threat. Both Israel and the UAE had independently developed sophisticated monitoring of Iranian military and intelligence activities in the Gulf and across the region, and normalization opened channels for institutional intelligence sharing that both governments had previously maintained at arm's length through third-party intermediaries . The UAE had also negotiated, as part of the broader Abraham Accords package, access to the US F-35 fighter jet — a capability enhancement that prompted significant concern in Israel, where the "qualitative military edge" doctrine (enshrined in US law) requires that any US weapons sale to Arab states not compromise Israel's military superiority . The F-35 sale to the UAE was subsequently complicated by the Biden administration's human rights concerns and technology transfer restrictions, and had not been completed as of mid-2024.

The NSO Group's Pegasus spyware controversy introduced friction into the UAE-Israel commercial relationship. Evidence emerged that Pegasus had been used to surveil UAE-based journalists and human rights advocates, and the relationship between Israeli intelligence technology companies and Gulf state security services attracted sustained investigative journalism and political attention in Europe and the United States .

Part II — Bahrain, Sudan, Morocco

Bahrain's normalization, signed on the same day as the UAE's on September 15, 2020, reflected its geopolitical dependency on Saudi acquiescence more than any independent strategic calculation. Bahrain's foreign policy is closely coordinated with Riyadh — it hosts the US Fifth Fleet partly through Saudi diplomatic facilitation and depends on the Saudi-led GCC architecture for its economic and security survival. The Trump administration and the Kushner team interpreted Bahrain's willingness to sign, without explicit Saudi objection, as a form of tacit Saudi blessing — a reading that influenced subsequent assessments of Saudi Arabia's own normalization trajectory . The Bahraini agreement produced more modest commercial outcomes than the UAE normalization, reflecting the significant asymmetry between the two economies.

The Sudan normalization of October 23, 2020 was explicitly transactional at the governmental level, with the US removal of Sudan from the State Sponsors of Terrorism list serving as the direct quid pro quo . Sudan had been on the terrorism list since 1993, partly due to the government of Omar al-Bashir having hosted Osama bin Laden in the 1990s. Al-Bashir had been deposed and placed under arrest following a popular uprising in April 2019, and the transitional government that replaced him was desperately seeking international rehabilitation and access to debt relief and investment . The transaction had the character of a diplomatic clearing house: Sudan got off the terrorism list; the Trump administration got an additional normalization agreement to announce; Israel got symbolic recognition from an African Muslim-majority state. The deeper logic — whether Sudan's populations and political institutions ever embraced normalisation — was largely absent from the calculation, as subsequent events demonstrated.

Morocco's normalization agreement of December 10, 2020 involved perhaps the most significant and geopolitically enduring US concession: formal recognition of Moroccan sovereignty over Western Sahara, a territory whose status had been the subject of a UN-sponsored self-determination process since 1991 . Morocco administers approximately 75% of Western Sahara and has long sought international recognition of its sovereignty claim against the POLISARIO Front (backed by Algeria) and a significant

UN and African Union institutional consensus favouring self-determination. The US recognition — unprecedented and reversed by no subsequent administration — provided Morocco with a diplomatic trophy that outweighed the political costs of normalization with Israel, which Morocco frames as having maintained de facto business and intelligence relations with for decades. Morocco's King Mohammed VI has maintained normalization while emphasising his country's continuing support for Palestinian rights — a careful balancing that has protected the political sustainability of the agreement domestically .

Oman played a distinctive background role throughout the Abraham Accords negotiations. Sultan Qaboos bin Said, who died in January 2020, had cultivated Oman as a discreet intermediary between Israel and the Arab world for decades, hosting Prime Minister Netanyahu in a publicly announced visit in October 2018 — the most significant visit by an Israeli leader to a non-peace treaty Arab state since Yitzhak Rabin . Oman did not join the Abraham Accords but maintained its back-channel diplomatic role under Sultan Haitham bin Tariq.

Part III — The Saudi Normalization Talks

Saudi Arabia's potential normalisation with Israel represented — and continues to represent — a qualitatively different proposition from any previous Arab-Israeli agreement, for reasons that extend beyond Saudi Arabia's geopolitical weight as the Arab world's most significant power and the world's largest oil producer. The Custodianship of the Two Holy Mosques — the formal title of the Saudi king — invests Saudi Arabia's position on Palestine with a religious authority that other Arab normalising states lack: any Saudi agreement with Israel touches the deepest structures of Islamic political legitimacy in a way that UAE, Bahraini, Moroccan, or Sudanese agreements do not .

The US-Saudi framework for normalization discussions, which advanced significantly through 2022 and into 2023, involved three interconnected components that Riyadh insisted must be addressed simultaneously. The first and most consequential was a US-Saudi mutual defence treaty that would provide Saudi Arabia with a formal Article 5-equivalent security guarantee — a commitment that no Arab state had ever received from the United States and that would place the US-Saudi relationship on the same formal treaty footing as the US-European NATO alliance . The second component was a US-Saudi civilian nuclear cooperation agreement — a "123 agreement" under Section 123 of the US Atomic Energy Act — that, critically, would permit Saudi Arabia to enrich uranium on its own soil rather than accepting the UAE's "gold standard" formula that forswears enrichment and reprocessing . The third component was the Israeli dimension: Saudi Arabia demanded a "credible pathway" to a Palestinian state, an ambiguous formulation that stopped short of requiring an actual state as a precondition but required Israeli political commitment to a two-state horizon that Netanyahu's coalition with Ben Gvir and Smotrich was constitutionally incapable of offering.

Secretary of State Antony Blinken reported in public statements and congressional testimony in September 2023 that the normalization talks were "very close" and represented the Biden administration's primary diplomatic priority for the fall of 2023 . The assessment of multiple analysts, including former senior US government officials, was that a deal was achievable by end-2023 or early 2024 — a timeline that October 7 destroyed.

The Hamas attack on October 7, 2023 was interpreted by multiple analysts, and explicitly argued by Qatari officials in private diplomatic communications subsequently reported in Western media, as motivated in significant part by Hamas leadership's determination to prevent Saudi-Israeli normalization, which would have fundamentally isolated Hamas and undermined the argument that armed resistance rather than Arab state diplomacy served Palestinian interests . Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's post-October 7 public statements emphasised that Saudi Arabia had "never recognised Israel" and that normalization was impossible without a Palestinian state — language that was more categorical than pre-October 7 Saudi positioning but that simultaneously preserved the Saudi-US relationship and kept

Part IV — Palestinian Authority and Two-State Solution

The Palestinian Authority under President Mahmoud Abbas — 88 years old in 2026, in office since the death of Yasser Arafat in November 2004, with his last democratic mandate from a 2005 election held for a four-year term — has presided over a progressive erosion of Palestinian governance legitimacy that makes the "day after" question in Gaza structurally intractable . The PA governs Area A of the West Bank (approximately 18% of total West Bank territory under Oslo Accords framework) and exercises nominal administrative control over Area B, while Israel retains full security control over Area C (approximately 60% of the West Bank, including most of the land on which Israeli settlements have been constructed) .

The settlement enterprise has fundamentally altered the physical geography of any potential Palestinian state. The settler population in the West Bank grew from approximately 250,000 at the time of the Oslo Accords in 1993 to over 700,000 by 2026, distributed across more than 140 formal settlements and dozens of additional outposts . This population is distributed across the West Bank in a pattern that fractures territorial contiguity and that, in the assessments of former senior US diplomats and international legal scholars, makes a physically viable Palestinian state increasingly difficult to demarcate on any map .

Hamas's governance of Gaza since its violent seizure of power in June 2007 — displacing the Fatah-dominated Palestinian Authority in five days of urban fighting — created the foundational split in Palestinian politics that has made Palestinian statehood structurally impossible to negotiate: no single Palestinian interlocutor commands authority over both Gaza and the West Bank, and neither Hamas nor the PA has demonstrated willingness to submit to the other's authority . The PA rejected the Abraham Accords on the grounds that Arab states had normalised relations with Israel without extracting any Palestinian political concessions — an assessment substantiated by the agreements' text, which makes no binding commitment to a Palestinian state and whose West Bank annexation suspension has never been converted into a permanent commitment.

The "day after" problem — who governs Gaza after the military phase of the IDF campaign — has no solution that satisfies Israel, the United States, Arab partner states, and Palestinian political realities simultaneously. The four broad options considered by US, Israeli, and Arab governments — a return of the PA to Gaza, a new alternative Palestinian administration, an Israeli military administration, or an international peacekeeping force — each faces insurmountable objections: the PA lacks the security capacity and political legitimacy to govern Gaza against Hamas resistance; no credible alternative Palestinian leadership has emerged; Israeli military administration would be opposed by the United States, the Arab world, and most of the international community; and an international force would require a Security Council mandate that Russia and China could veto .

Part V — Post-October 7 Normalization Landscape (2025–2026)

The Phase 1 ceasefire of January 2025 created the first minimal conditions under which normalization diplomacy could theoretically resume, but the political, humanitarian, and legal landscape of post-October 7 Middle East has altered the calculus in ways that make a near-term return to the pre-October 7 normalization trajectory implausible. Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman has been explicit that normalization requires both a tangible Gaza reconstruction pathway and a credible Palestinian state political commitment — conditions that the Netanyahu government is structurally incapable of accepting and that a post-Netanyahu government would face severe domestic political obstacles in delivering .

The Trump 2.0 administration has characterised Saudi-Israeli normalization as the "biggest deal in history" if achievable and has deployed Secretary of State Marco Rubio and special envoys in sustained diplomatic effort toward this goal — continuing the architecture that Kushner had built, now with the added leverage of Trump's personal relationship with MBS . The structural incentives that drove the pre-October 7 discussions remain intact: Saudi Arabia wants the US mutual defence guarantee, US civilian nuclear cooperation rights, and the political cover that comes with an Israel relationship as it navigates its Vision 2030 economic transformation. These are strategic interests of the first order that have not changed because of October 7 — only the political timeline for achieving them has.

The durability of the existing Abraham Accords agreements has been tested but not broken. Morocco-Israel normalization has been the most resilient, with bilateral trade and security cooperation continuing throughout the conflict period, buffered by Morocco's geographic distance from the conflict and King Mohammed VI's careful domestic political management . The UAE's relationship with Israel has been strained by domestic public opinion pressure and the broader Arab world's reaction to the Gaza humanitarian catastrophe, but has not been formally suspended — the UAE government's hostility toward Hamas (which it has designated a terrorist organisation) aligns with Israel's objective of dismantling Hamas, even where it diverges on methods . Bahrain formally maintained normalization while its government navigated intense domestic pressure from its Shia majority population and from Bahraini civil society. Sudan's normalization was effectively inactive, the Sudanese transitional government consumed by the catastrophic civil war that erupted in April 2023 between the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces, which has since produced one of the world's most acute humanitarian crises .

Oman quietly maintained an ambassador to Israel through the conflict period — an understated but symbolically significant diplomatic choice that preserved the back-channel functionality that has historically made Oman valuable as an intermediary . The preservation of the Oman channel, combined with the continued engagement of Qatar (despite its Hamas relationship) and Egypt, maintained the minimal diplomatic infrastructure needed to conduct hostage negotiations and manage ceasefire sequencing.

Conclusion

The Abraham Accords' fundamental durability test is not whether they survive October 7 — they have, in attenuated form — but whether the normalization framework can eventually integrate Saudi Arabia under conditions that provide genuine Palestinian political progress. The structural logic of normalization has not changed: the Gulf states face Iran as their primary security threat and see Israel's intelligence and military capabilities as genuinely useful in managing that threat; the Palestinian leadership vacuum and the collapse of the two-state solution's physical preconditions mean that Arab states are increasingly normalising without Palestinian preconditions regardless of their public statements; and the US desire to consolidate a Middle Eastern alignment against Iran and China provides sustained American diplomatic energy toward Saudi normalisation. The long-term trajectory of Arab-Israeli normalization is likely to continue despite October 7 — but only in a post-Gaza political environment that does not yet exist, and only under Israeli political leadership that is not the current government.

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